

Q Will I have to give up running? I want to stay fit and feel my best throughout my pregnancy.

You can keep up some sports, such as running, for as long as feels comfortable and is medically safe; then switch to low- or no-impact sports later on so you can continue exercising.

Low-impact exercise This exerts minimal stress on your weight-bearing joints.



As long as you are a seasoned runner, continuing to run during your first trimester and into your second trimester is fine if you feel well and comfortable. You may find that the increasing weight of the baby and your changing center of gravity mean that you won't want to run as far or as fast as before, and you may tire more quickly. Avoid running on bumpy or icy ground so you don't fall. After 12 weeks of pregnancy, check with your doctor about how long it is safe for you to continue.

With any high-impact sport, you should follow a few rules while pregnant. Warm up and cool down gently and don't overstretch: unlike muscles, which regain their shape after the birth, ligaments will not recover if stretched excessively. Exercise moderately below your usual fitness levels; you should be able to talk easily while you exercise—so avoid pushing yourself too hard. If you overheat, the fetus may suffer, particularly in the first trimester when it can't regulate its own temperature. If you are out of breath for a period it may reduce the amount of oxygen the fetus receives. It's especially important to rehydrate properly afterward, since dehydration can lead to complications including premature contractions.

Do not attempt any high-impact, high-risk, or contact sports if you exercised intermittently before becoming pregnant, or are new to exercise.



Did you know...

Exercise has the happy consequence of causing the brain's transmitters to release endorphins into the brain and nervous system. These hormones have a number of physiological functions, including triggering a positive feeling and reducing stress, helping to boost your mood.

WHICH SPORTS TO ENJOY AND FOR HOW LONG

Exercise is a wonderful way to maintain your energy levels and feel good, but you may need to exercise within a different set of parameters as you move through each trimester.

SPORT	PROS & CONS	FIRST & SECOND TRIMESTER
Swimming	Strengthens your heart and lungs and tones your muscles while supporting all your weight and keeping your body temperature stable.	Ideal for all levels of fitness. Sign up for water aerobics classes if available.
Badminton	A low-impact aerobic sport that promotes cardiovascular health.	As with most racket sports, unless you are a regular player, don't play while pregnant. Try other low-impact alternatives.
Cycling	Gives you a cardio workout while supporting your weight so there is less stress on your body.	Use a stationary bike and don't overexert yourself. Cool down afterward.
Golf	Low-impact golf works core muscles, helps to improve stability, and improves cardiovascular health if you walk the course.	Continue if you already play golf regularly, but stretch well first, adjust your game to "slow and easy," and be careful not to lose your balance.
Gym	Has a variety of equipment and exercise classes to give you a cardio workout and strength training (use light weights only).	Exercise at a moderate intensity on machinery. Sign up for pregnancy exercise classes.
Hiking & climbing	Hiking improves your strength and cardiovascular health. Climbing is not advised.	Consult your doctor first before going hiking, then choose even terrain and make sure you have supportive hiking boots and hiking poles.
Pilates	Focuses on core muscles—abdominal, pelvic floor, and back—to promote good posture, stability, and strength without straining other joints.	Ideal for all levels of fitness, but for safety, make sure your instructor knows that you are pregnant.
Walking & power walking	Strengthens your heart and lungs, tones your muscles, and is safe for your body.	Walk for 30 minutes three times a week if you are a beginner. If you are fit, focus on power walking—walking at a brisk pace—to raise your heart rate.
Yoga	Gives you techniques to help you breathe, move, stretch, and relax while pregnant. Also strengthens your muscles. Avoid hot yoga.	Ideal for all levels of fitness. For safety's sake, tell the yoga instructor that you are pregnant.
Dancing	Gives you a good cardio workout, but can stress the joints. Always keep one foot on the ground and avoid spinning, leaping, jumping, and so on.	Continue if you already dance regularly, but exercise below your usual fitness levels.
Running	Elevates your heart rate and works your muscles, but can cause stress to your joints.	Continue if you run regularly, but listen to your body during your second trimester in particular.
Tennis	Gives you a cardio workout, but rapid changes in direction can stress your joints and cause falls.	Unless you are a fit and very experienced player, don't play while pregnant. Try low-impact alternatives.